



June 25, 2026

Bernalillo County Planning Commission
415 Silver Avenue SW
Albuquerque, NM 87102

RE: Appeal of Conditional Use Approval – Albuquerque Islamic Center, 9600 2nd Street NW

Dear Chair and Members of the Planning Commission:

On behalf of the Albuquerque International Balloon Fiesta, Inc. ("AIBF"), I am writing regarding the conditional use approval granted by the Bernalillo County Zoning Administrator for the Albuquerque Islamic Center at 9600 2nd Street NW.

Our concerns are limited solely to the potential transportation, traffic management, public safety, and operational compatibility impacts associated with the proposed development's location within a critical transportation corridor serving Balloon Fiesta Park and the annual Albuquerque International Balloon Fiesta. AIBF's interest in this matter arises from its responsibility to ensure the continued safe and efficient operation of Balloon Fiesta activities and the transportation infrastructure that supports those activities. Accordingly, the comments set forth below are directed exclusively at those operational and public safety considerations.

The subject property is located along the 2nd Street NW corridor, which serves as a primary access route for Balloon Fiesta operations. During the annual event, this corridor accommodates significant volumes of sponsor, pilot, crew, volunteer, vendor, and emergency vehicles, and supports traffic entering and exiting Balloon Fiesta Park. Efficient operation of this corridor is essential to public safety, traffic management, and the overall success of an event that attracts hundreds of thousands of visitors and generates substantial economic benefit for Bernalillo County and the State of New Mexico.

Based upon the information available to AIBF, it is unclear whether a comprehensive traffic impact study was conducted as part of the conditional use application process. Given the location of the property and the unique traffic conditions associated with Balloon Fiesta operations, we respectfully request that the Planning Commission determine whether a traffic impact analysis has been prepared and made part of the record.

If no such study has been completed, AIBF respectfully requests that the Commission require a professional traffic impact study prior to affirming the conditional use approval. Such a study should evaluate both typical daily traffic conditions and the extraordinary traffic demands that occur during Balloon Fiesta operations. In addition, the site plan depicts a school or

educational component as part of the proposed development. If such a use is contemplated, the traffic impact study should specifically evaluate the additional traffic generated by student drop-off and pick-up activities, employee traffic, special events, and other school-related operations, as these uses may substantially affect traffic volumes and circulation patterns along the 2nd Street NW corridor.

At a minimum, the study should address:

1. Existing and projected traffic volumes associated with the proposed use.
2. Peak attendance estimates and associated vehicle trip generation, including the school or educational use depicted on the site plan and any associated educational, daycare, or instructional activities.
3. Impacts to adjacent intersections and roadway segments, including 2nd Street NW, Alameda Boulevard, and surrounding access routes.
4. Site ingress and egress operations, turning movements, and potential vehicle queuing.
5. Parking supply, parking demand, and potential overflow parking impacts.
6. Effects on emergency access and public safety operations.
7. Traffic conditions during Balloon Fiesta events, including sponsor, pilot, crew, volunteer, vendor, emergency, and operational traffic movements.
8. Potential mitigation measures necessary to maintain safe and efficient traffic operations.

AIBF is particularly concerned that traffic conditions experienced during major religious services, special events, holidays, community gatherings, and activities associated with the school depicted on the site plan may coincide with periods when the transportation network is already operating under significant demand. Without a thorough analysis, it is difficult to determine whether the proposed use can be accommodated without adversely affecting public safety and transportation efficiency.

In addition to transportation concerns, AIBF requests clarification regarding the proposed site's compatibility with Balloon Fiesta operations. Because the property is located within an area routinely affected by balloon overflights and occasional balloon landings during Balloon Fiesta events, AIBF respectfully requests that the Commission ensure the record contains sufficient information to evaluate potential operational compatibility issues.

While AIBF understands that applicable zoning regulations do not prohibit construction of a two-story building at this location, AIBF remains concerned about the height of any proposed structure due to the site's close proximity to areas routinely utilized for balloon overflights and occasional balloon landings. Accordingly, AIBF requests that the Commission carefully evaluate the proposed building height and any potential effects the structure may have on balloon operations, public safety, landing activities, and retrieval operations associated with the Balloon Fiesta.

Specifically, AIBF requests clarification regarding:

1. The proposed site plan, architectural elevations, building heights, and the nature and scope of the school or educational facility depicted on the site plan, including anticipated enrollment, staffing, and hours of operation.

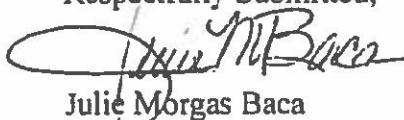
2. The location, height, and intensity of any exterior lighting, parking lot lighting, or light poles proposed as part of the development.
3. Any proposed antennae, communications facilities, radio infrastructure, video transmission equipment, or other structures that could affect aviation-related activities or Balloon Fiesta operations.
4. The proposed site access configuration, including whether ingress and egress will be limited to right-in/right-out movements and how traffic circulation will be managed considering the property's proximity to Alameda Boulevard.
5. Any analysis of anticipated turning movements and traffic circulation patterns associated with peak attendance periods.
6. Whether the traffic impacts associated with the school or educational facility depicted on the site plan, including student drop-off and pick-up activity, employee traffic, special events, and peak-period operations, have been fully evaluated as part of a comprehensive traffic impact study.
7. Any operational procedures or policies related to accommodating occasional balloon landings and retrieval activities that may occur during Balloon Fiesta events.
8. Whether the applicant has identified any concerns regarding existing balloon overflight activities in the area and, if so, how such concerns would be addressed while maintaining established Balloon Fiesta operations.

AIBF believes that these issues are relevant to evaluating whether the proposed development can coexist with the unique operational demands associated with Balloon Fiesta Park and the annual Balloon Fiesta event.

Accordingly, AIBF respectfully requests that the Planning Commission carefully review the transportation and operational compatibility impacts associated with the proposed development and require any necessary studies, mitigation measures, or conditions of approval needed to protect the public interest and preserve the safe and efficient operation of this important transportation corridor.

Thank you for your consideration of these comments. We appreciate the Planning Commission's attention to these issues and would welcome the opportunity to provide additional information if requested. AIBF remains available to engage in further discussions with the Commission, County staff, and the applicant, and stands ready to answer questions, provide additional information, and assist in identifying solutions that protect public safety and support the continued efficient operation of Balloon Fiesta activities.

Respectfully Submitted,



Julie Morgas Baca
Executive Director
Albuquerque International Balloon Fiesta

c: Neil Jackson, President, AIBF
Nicholas Hamm, Director, Planning and Development Services